ROLEEDGE · STUDY ABROAD

University Admissions Checklist

Your Step-by-Step Guide to Winning Admits at Top Global Universities

13	11	Print
SECTIONS	EXERCISES	WITH SPACE TO WRITE

> **How to use this guide:** print it, work through it in order, and write in the spaces. Every exercise has room for your answers, and you can print extra copies of any page.

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From **RoleEdge**, founded by Mayank Kapoor, former Manager at Bain & Company and Warwick MBA. Free to use and share.

Why an Admissions Checklist Matters

Applying to top universities is overwhelming: multiple deadlines, essays, test scores, and recommendation letters all competing for your attention. Without structure, it's easy to miss opportunities.

An admissions checklist is your **blueprint**—it ensures you don't just apply, but apply with strategy and excellence. Every top admit—Harvard, Oxford, INSEAD, ISB—requires clarity, storytelling, and discipline.

REFLECTION

Write why you want to pursue higher education—career pivot, leadership growth, or global exposure.

STEP 1

Define Your Target Programs & Career Goals

Before you chase rankings, get clear on goals.

- Do you want consulting post-MBA? Target INSEAD, Kellogg, LBS.
- Do you want finance? Look at Wharton, Columbia, ISB.
- Do you want tech/product? Consider Stanford, Berkeley Haas.

EXERCISE

Write your short-term (post-program job) and long-term (10-year career vision) goals.

	My goal
Short term (first job after the programme)	
Long term (10-year vision)	

STEP 2

Shortlisting Universities – Dream, Target, Safety

Use the **DTS Framework**:

- **Dream Schools:** Aspirational (Harvard, Oxford, INSEAD).
- **Target Schools:** Competitive but realistic.
- **Safety Schools:** Solid chances of admission.

EXERCISE

List 2–3 universities under each bucket.

Dream	Target	Safety

STEP 3

Understanding Admission Requirements

Each university evaluates 4 dimensions:

- **Academics:** GPA, transcripts.
- **Test Scores:** GMAT, GRE, IELTS/TOEFL.
- **Professional Experience:** Impact, leadership.
- **Application Materials:** Resume, essays, recommendations.

EXERCISE

Pick 1 target school and list its admission requirements.

Requirement	What the school asks for	My status
Academics		
Test scores		
Experience		
Resume, essays, recommendations		

STEP 4

Building a Strong Resume for Admissions

Admissions resumes differ from job resumes. They must highlight:

- Leadership & initiative.
- Impact with quantified metrics.
- Academic and extracurricular achievements.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Instead of “Worked on audit projects” → “Led 3-member team on Fortune 500 audit, improving reporting accuracy by 15%.”

EXERCISE

Rewrite one of your resume bullets for admissions.

STEP 5

Crafting Your Personal Statement/Essays

Essays = storytelling. They answer:

- Why this program?
- Why now?
- Why you?

Framework: Past → Present → Future.

Example: Past = finance background, Present = interest in ESG, Future = global ESG leader.

EXERCISE

Write 3 sentences connecting your past, present, and future into a story.

	My story
Past	
Present	
Future	

STEP 6

Letters of Recommendation – Strategy & Guidance

Recommendations should validate your story.

- Pick recommenders who **know you**, not just senior titles.
- Provide them a draft with examples of your leadership.
- Ensure consistency with your essays.

EXERCISE

List 2 people who can write authentic recommendations for you.

Recommender	How they know me

STEP 7

Preparing for Standardized Tests

- **GMAT/GRE:** Practise quant and verbal daily. Aim at or above the median in each school's latest class profile.
- **IELTS/TOEFL:** Focus on fluency + writing clarity.
- Start prep at least 6–9 months before deadlines.

EXERCISE

Write your target GMAT/GRE score and exam date.

Test	Target score	Exam date
GMAT / GRE		
IELTS / TOEFL (if needed)		

STEP 8

Application Timelines & Deadlines

Typical timelines:

- Round 1: September–October.
- Round 2: January–February.
- Round 3: around April.

WORKSHEET

Create a 12-month calendar marking test dates, essay deadlines, and application submissions.

Month	Tests	Essays	Submissions

STEP 9

Preparing for Admissions Interviews

Universities test: communication, clarity, fit.

Common questions:

- Why MBA/Masters now?
- Why this school?
- Tell me about a leadership experience.

EXERCISE

Record yourself answering 1 question. Time yourself—stay under 2 minutes.

STEP 10

Financing Your Education

Options:

- **Scholarships:** Merit, need-based.
- **Loans:** Prodigy Finance, MPower, local banks.
- **Grants:** Some universities provide research or assistantship roles.

EXERCISE

Write 2 scholarship/loan options you'd explore.

1. _____
2. _____

EXAMPLE

Worked examples

An illustrative example. Names and details are representative, not real clients.

An Indian business school admit: Riya, a chartered accountant from a Big Four firm, refined her essays around her leadership impact. She won an admit with a scholarship.

A UK MBA admit: Arjun, a former strategy consulting analyst, reframed his resume and essays around his social impact goals, and prepared hard for the interview.

> LESSON
>
> Clarity + Storytelling + Proof of Impact wins.

Common Mistakes and Your 90-Day Plan

- ✕ Copy-pasting essays across schools.
- ✕ Overemphasizing GPA while ignoring leadership.
- ✕ Missing deadlines by poor planning.

Your 90-day plan

When	Focus	My actions
Days 1–30	Shortlist + Resume.	
Days 31–60	Essays + Recommendations.	
Days 61–90	Interview prep + submissions.	

My notes

NEXT STEP

Want someone to check your work?

Bring this guide to a free call with RoleEdge. We'll go through your answers and help you plan what comes next.

Book a free call at roleedge.com/book